

TREATING PORNOGRAPHY ADDICTION WITH IFS

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Internet pornography, which includes violence and sex with children, is a billion dollar industry that generates more revenue than all of professional sports combined (Maltz & Maltz, 2008). Addictive parts can spend hours looking at and forming relationships with erotic images, which can impede an individual's functioning at work and in love. Pornography addiction is physiological and these images are arousing even if someone is not interested (Maltz & Maltz, 2008). As a result, clients can have great difficulty quitting. There is always a strong polarity between the firefighter parts of clients who use pornography and the critical, shaming managers who try to stop them.

A 68-year-old man named Herb came to me for help with a pornography addiction. He wanted to figure out how this addiction had happened and he wanted to stop. He was a bright, educated man who had been given the diagnosis of panic disorder in addition to bipolar disorder in his early 40s. His mother, who also had a diagnosis of bipolar disorder, had disappeared into her bedroom for days at a time throughout his childhood, and he wanted to manage his illness more responsibly. So he left a stressful job to work on computer programming at home. But working at home soon became a problem because he could turn to online pornography whenever he felt frustrated. In addition to losing hours to the computer he also lost interest in having sex with his wife. Herb tried psychotherapy but it had no effect on his addiction.

When I asked Herb to focus on the urge to look at pornographic images, he had a vivid memory of being in first grade and seeing the under-pants of his classmate, Sally, when, as she took off her snowsuit, her slacks came off by mistake. Herb had begun fantasizing at night about those white underpants. He had liked this mental picture so much that he invented a multiplying machine that could create as many Sallys in white panties as he wished. At age ten, he had discovered masturbation and quickly learned to enhance the experience by looking at images of movie stars in Parade magazine from the Sunday paper. In high school he found an "electrifying" cache of photographs of women dressed in shorts and tight sweaters or bikini bathing suits behind a panel of loose wallpaper in his bedroom closet. With these images in hand, Herb became a compulsive masturbator, a secret life that generated great shame and precluded interest in real girls. Over the years he masturbated in library stalls after looking at

college girls, in adult theaters where he could view people having sex or watch women onscreen disrobing. With the advent of Internet pornography, he continued at home during his first marriage, and, with increased intensity, after the end of his marriage and on into another marriage until his second wife finally confronted him.

As with many who are addicted to pornography, Herb had a hard time locating parts in his body. Instead, he noticed them in his head and at first they could not give Herb any space to be there as well. Early on we met a part called Rational Man. This part did not believe the pornography addict was a part, much less that it was trying to help Herb. “It’s pure chemistry,” Rational Man said. “A short skirt or panties simply make me feel sex in my crotch.”

“If that were the case, what would it mean?” I asked.

“That the urge just has to be controlled,” Rational Man said.

“What makes you so sure the urge to look at pornography is not a part who is doing something important for Herb?” I asked, using direct access to speak to Rational Man.

“It’s a bad habit that I got into because of my DNA,” Rational Man replied. “It’s just the way this body is.”

“You may be right,” I said, “but if it were another part and Herb could help that part, would that be good for you?”

“I suppose so, assuming by ‘help’ you mean stop it,” Rational Man replied.

“Let me explain how I view this,” I said. “I believe Herb looks at pornography for a reason, so we could say the porn addiction started as a solution to a problem—and then unfortunately it became a problem, too. My experience says if we can solve the original problem there won’t be a need to look at pornography anymore.”

“Well,” Rational Man said with a shrug, “nothing else helps.”

“So it’s OK with you if Herb and I ask the part why it urges him to use pornography?” I asked and Herb nodded.

But despite this permission, Herb now noticed a growing fear located, as usual, in his head. When I asked the fear if it would unblend, Herb said, “I feel like this fear is me.”

“OK. Can we try inviting the fear to give you the space to be there, too?” I asked.

After some deep breaths, Herb relaxed visibly and reported that he could feel the fear separate a little bit.

“How do you feel toward it?” I asked.

“Interested,” he said. After some moments, he reported, “It’s afraid of getting caught.” Herb validated this concern and assured the part that our therapy was confidential. The fearful part then gave us permission to continue and I asked if he could notice the part who liked white panties.

“I cannot locate it. I just imagine the panties and feel aroused,” he said.

“Do you notice anything else?” I asked.

“I notice that I feel really embarrassed talking to you about this,” he said.

At this point I decided to map Herb’s parts to help the embarrassed part. Mapping is a powerful unblending tool that helps parts to differentiate, which is particularly important with embarrassment and shame. “OK,” I said, getting out a clipboard with blank paper and markers, “so right now we know that one part is afraid of getting caught, another loves white panties, and another is embarrassed that you’re

telling me about it. Can you draw these three parts? What size are they and where are they in relation to each other?" Herb drew a large pink cloud in the center; above the cloud in black he wrote the word *fear* and below he wrote *shame*. "When you look at that what do you notice?" I asked.

"I drew the white panties in pink because pink feels feminine and soft," he said. "The panties are a fluffy, soft cloud I could float on. The cloud is warm and comfortable, like being in the arms of a woman you know and love."

"OK," I said. "What do you notice about the part who feels shame?"

"That part is less clear. I feel it like a fog at the back of my head but I have no image. And this fear has been around since high school; it's a buzzing in the front of my head. If anyone knew that I was jerking off to pornography I would have been the laughing stock of the whole school, but especially the girls," he said. "The fear part would show me the girls looking repulsed and disgusted after finding out what I was doing in secret. It's the worst punishment I could imagine."

At our next session Herb described developing a twitch in his right eye and mild tightness in his chest. He said he had been feeling irritable and anxious after looking at pornographic images on the Internet. "Would it be OK to pay attention to that?" I asked. He nodded. "OK then take a couple of deep breaths and notice the chest pain," I said.

"I am angry that I lost control," Herb said.

"How do you feel toward that anger?" I asked.

"I understand it. This part feels it's important to be in control all the time. It demands that I be perfect. Before I went freelance, my job at the firm was very competitive. I began to have panic attacks when I was preparing a project or had to present my ideas to the group and this part got furious with me."

"What happens when it gets furious?"

"It tells me I'm a failure and a phony and I'll never be able to compete."

"It shames you?"

"Yes," Herb said.

"How old does it think you are?"

Herb, whose eyes were closed, was quiet for a moment. "About 10 years old."

"Can you let the angry part know that you are not the 10-year-old but that you can help the 10-year-old?"

"OK it's relaxing. I don't feel so angry. But now I am noticing anxiety in my chest."

"Would it be OK to focus there?" I asked, anticipating that this anxiety would lead either to the other side of the polarity or to an exiled part who had been chronically shamed.

After a minute Herb reported that the anxious part was afraid of having a panic attack. He had compassion for the part and reported that it always felt inadequate, spent most of its time in hiding and did not want him working in an office with coworkers.

"This part has been ashamed my whole life," he said. "He's telling me he got it from my mother. She was an anxious person but especially about bodies and sex. He just soaked up her shame and embarrassment."

"How old is he?"

"Maybe 6 years old? He's showing me how he feels bad about his genitals."

"How do you feel toward him," I asked.

“I want to tell him that he’s fine,” Herb said.

“Go ahead.”

After Herb explained that there was nothing wrong with his body, the boy perked up. He was not ready to unburden these feelings and questions about himself but he did want to go on showing Herb about his experience. At the end of the session, Herb observed that all sex and intimacy with women evoked feelings of shame. He could only soar into orgasm when he was completely alone.

The next week we went over the parts we had met so far. There was the exile who carried his mother’s shame and anxiety about bodies and sexuality; the firefighter who encouraged Herb’s addiction to pornography; and then, polarized with this firefighter, there was an intensely critical, shaming manager who attacked Herb for his lack of self-control with pornography (Rosenberg, this volume; Sweezy, this volume). Herb said he could now understand them all. “I really get how much I wanted to help my mother as a child. I could feel her embarrassment and pain,” he said. “And I believed her embarrassment meant something about me, that I must be causing it somehow.”

“Is there anything else he needs to show you about his experience?”

“Not about this.”

“What needs to happen for him now?”

“He just wants to feel love for his mother,” Herb reported.

After this session Herb noticed a black hole around his heart that was about the size and shape of a football. “It is something that wants to be a feeling but is hollow instead,” he said. Herb noticed this black hole between sessions and, although he was almost too ashamed to speak of having slipped, he finally admitted that he had been using pornography to masturbate again since finding it. I explained to Herb that I expected upticks in addictive behavior to occur as we began to locate and unburden his exiled parts. The challenge for the therapist in a case like this is to not manage the firefighter but instead to calm shaming managers and attend to the exile. We spent a whole session getting to Herb’s Self-energy and his ability to feel curious toward this emptiness around his heart, which he discovered held many memories of being shamed in grade and high school. As he started to work on historical shame, he found a part who feared criticism.

“OK to notice this part?” I asked.

“Yes,” Herb said. “He protects a younger one who looks like me as a little boy. He’s with my family but he’s got a shell around him. He’s the youngest and everyone is talking and laughing and telling stories but when he tries to join in nobody wants to hear his story. His brother is telling him to shut up. And when he gets mad about that his father tells him, ‘Shhhhhh!’ ”

“How do you feel toward him?” I asked.

“I had a part that wanted to hide him at first but I got that part to relax and now I’m asking him to tell me his story. His shell is dissolving.”

The next week Herb reported that his compulsion for pornography had relaxed and he felt relieved. “But,” I predicted, “it may come back as you get close to this little boy or to other vulnerable parts. Don’t worry, once you have taken care of the ones this protector looks after, the urge for porn will go.”

As I had predicted, in the next session Herb said that his pornography compulsion was back strongly. “Is it OK to notice the urge?” I asked.

Herb said it was just outside his head on the right. He felt frustrated toward the porn part, which seemed out of control again. “But I feel frustrated toward outside people, too,” Herb said. “The frustrated part rehearses things he will say to people who are arrogant or pushy.” After getting curious, Herb reported, “He’s showing me how I was bullied by another kid every morning in fifth grade walking to school.”

“How do you feel toward the fifth-grader?” I asked.

“I feel sad for him. It was so hard walking to school every day with this bully slapping him around and making fun of him.” Herb helped the fifth-grader escape the bully and come to the present, where he unburdened his fear and shame.

After unburdening an exile we always returned to check in with the pornography part. While looking at porn, Herb now noticed that he was having a conversation with a faceless female. She stood behind him and watched the images too. This female part understood exactly what Herb liked and shared his pleasure. She was his personal madam who procured women and directed them for him, reading his thoughts, approving his whims and never judging him. Watching porn with her, Herb felt free and relaxed, the opposite of his experience with real women. These parts, the ones who pushed porn and the inner critic, represent a classic addictive polarity between firefighters who relieve shame and managers who stir it up again with criticism. As with all polarities, we would eventually find an exile underneath.

But in the meantime we were in a delicate moment of the therapy. As the client forms a relationship with an exiled part, protectors tend to become more extreme and more polarized. Between sessions Herb found he was either blended with the critic who told him he was doomed to a life of pornography and shame, or the pornography part who plagued him all night with intrusive fantasies. The intensity of this polarity was so hard to bear that another part emerged, a part who analyzed my actions, criticized me, questioned the effectiveness of internal family systems (IFS) and instructed Herb not to go inside or listen to me during sessions. I assured this part that its doubts were welcome and I encouraged Herb to get to know the part, which he called the Closet Snob.

Herb had always been a great student and had gone to elite schools. The Closet Snob had long helped Herb to feel better by looking down on others and questioning their intelligence. Although the Closet Snob had been comforting, Herb now saw how toxic his contempt was for relationships. “He keeps me from connecting,” Herb observed. “He doesn’t believe I know how to interact with people.”

Herb also noticed other protective parts who precluded intimacy. There was Front Man whose job was to hide Herb’s dark side by presenting a pleasant, friendly, inoffensive face when interacting with others. He wanted Herb to be seen as a contributor to society so that nobody would dream of viewing him as an outcast or a menace. And then, most important, Herb discovered a part who was protecting him from a bone-chilling fear, which turned out to be the feeling of Peter Pain.

“Peter Pain is showing me something that happened in second grade,” Herb said. “When Alice was threatened by the Queen of Hearts in *Alice’s Adventures in Wonderland*, I cried. The teacher sent me out into the hall where I couldn’t escape these older kids who always teased me.” Peter Pain showed Herb his big discovery. If he focused on feeling his genitals and called up feminine images while he was being humiliated he became aroused and distracted from his shame. Unburdening Peter Pain calmed the

pornography part and, in turn, the critic. Although all of the exiled parts described above carried shame and were important to unburden, Peter Pain, who carried experiences of being shamed by peers in school, turned out to be the linchpin exile for Herb's pornography habit.

CONCLUSIONS

The key to IFS work with pornography addiction is for the therapist, and eventually the client, to hold Self-energy while exploring the client's central polarity: the part who loves porn and the part who hates the client for looking at porn. Traditional sexual addiction therapy sides with the managers who try to shame the client out of using porn to self-soothe. In contrast, IFS offers both therapist and client a way to care about the parts who love porn as well as the parts who hate the client for being weak and embarrassing. Right from the start with Herb, I was curious and nonjudgmental about the part who looked at pornography. When the porn part explained to us that it longed for the comfort of pornographic pictures, Herb's critical, shaming managers immediately surfaced. The beginning of an addiction therapy always revolves around this polarity between firefighters and shaming managers. It is crucial not to side with the managers.

As with most pornography addicts Herb started treatment with little awareness of his body and, therefore, of his emotions. He initially located all parts in his head. The exercise of mapping parts on paper helped him to differentiate his protective parts by their roles as either managers (trying to prevent emotional pain) or firefighters (trying to suppress emotional pain). Direct access, another IFS technique that is effective with skeptical protectors, was also helpful with Herb. When the therapist addresses skeptical parts directly they will usually relax enough for the client to experience them as separate, or differentiated. Once the client differentiates and forms relationships with his protective system, through mapping and direct access, these vigilant parts will gradually give him more access to his body and, with enough Self-energy, exiles can begin to surface safely.

The last step in therapy is healing the exiles. But to reach the point of healing, the therapist must anticipate and welcome relapses. Firefighters will be triggered as the client makes contact with exiles who carry terror, humiliation and feelings of inadequacy, and it may look as if the therapy is failing. The therapist who stays present with the client as he reassures and loves his firefighters will hear about these relapses. And the therapist who holds Self-energy, tolerating critical managers as well as relapses with interest and compassion, is likely to get the opportunity to guide the client in witnessing and unburdening exiles, whether that happens explicitly or implicitly, freeing the client and his parts of this compulsive illusion of comfort.

REFERENCE

Maltz, W., & Maltz, L. (2008). *The porn trap: The essential guide to overcoming problems caused by pornography*. New York, NY: Harper/Collins.

